A Tree Fell and No One Saw

Every invention was once just a thought in a brain—or two brains, or three, or four… Every thought is a set of countless neurons firing together. Every neuron is made of protein. Every protein molecule consists mainly of carbon, hydrogen, nitrogen, and oxygen. Each of these elements was formed from primary elements like hydrogen and helium, which were created in the aftermath of the Big Bang.

"At long last, you found me," were the last words of the old man on his deathbed.

"I did, didn't I?" said the gorgeous woman in a casual sundress, smiling, as she stood before the bed. "But it's only the beginning. Trust me, I know you were looking for me your whole life, except you didn't know how to find me; in fact, you only longed for the *idea* of me, so you're right. I had no choice but to try to find you."

The old man took his last breath, the monitor beside him flatlining, but it would be hours before the nurse who was assigned to his care found out he was dead. The doctors and nurses were too busy attending to patients who needed immediate care, not someone whose life hung by a thread, literally—pulse oximeter sensors pinching his fingers and IV lines connected to his all-but-dry veins.

Since the old man had neither married nor adopted a child, there was no one to mourn him. He was no more than an entry in the receptionist's spreadsheet. The nursing home would send his body to be cremated. His bed would be cleaned, sanitized (possibly exorcised by that one particular superstitious nurse), and occupied with another dying person. But, as per his wish,

his ashes would be spread on the Moon during the next lunar mission, making it his greatest achievement wrapped up in a shroud of pity as a failed astrophysicist.

On a notepad page on his bedside table, in a barely legible hand, was written:

I finally heard the stars speaking, talking praise of their offspring, like all mothers do.

"Why do you look familiar?" the old man asked, the manifestation of his consciousness—like a transparent VR avatar—peeled off his body as he floated toward her in his pee-stained robe.

"So that we could skip the part where we have to form some kind of…bond of trust."

"I understand," he said, trying hard to remember. "You—you resemble my high school sweetheart, don't you?"

"There!" the woman exclaimed. "Bond of trust."

"But you never got to become a grown woman." He scratched his incorporeal head as he added quickly, "How—I mean, uh—what was your name? Tell me."

"Names are irrelevant," she said. "We don't need that."

"What comes now?"

"You humans are always yearning for the next part instead of enjoying the present." She chuckled. "But don't worry. Like I said, it's only the beginning. We have a long way to go to fulfill your lifelong desire—or as long as it takes."

“And what is my lifelong desire, exactly? You see, my frail memory has caught up with me even after leaving my mortal body. I’m still this useless old man who needs assistance just to stand.” A few days ago, while he was struggling to take a dump, he overheard a heated argument. The director was complaining they were running out of beds.

“I must first say,” the woman said, “that you’ve taken your death in stride. Bravo for that.”

“That’s because I was looking forward to it, but now that it’s here—” He shrugged.

“You’re looking for what comes next,” she finished. “I get it. I totally get it.”

He nodded. “Let’s go somewhere else. I can’t stand this room anymore.”

“As you wish,” the woman said, snapping her fingers.

They were transported under the shade of a huge, solitary tree. Before them loomed a redbrick high school. While the woman was still in her sundress, the old man was supported by a walking stick, wearing a beret, a pair of flared pants, a light shirt, and a dark suit vest over it. The sun shone so brightly the neatly trimmed grass on the ground looked almost white. A bell chimed, and students poured out of the front door, scattering across the ground in twos and threes.

“My high school,” the old man said reminiscently, limping out of the shade into the sunlight.

“Ready to meet yourself?”

“Like a time traveler?”

“No, merely a passive observer.”

“Like two time-traveling ghosts,” he said, stubbornly.

“Sure, if that’s what you prefer.”

“I like the sound of that.”

“You don’t have to go anywhere or do anything unless you can remember your lifelong desire right now,” she said.

“Why is it so important?”

“Just do as I say.”

“Who are you?” the old man asked. “A better question would be, *what* are you?”

“I am what you made me.”

“*I* made you?” He gaped.

“Oh, yes, you did. It took a majority of your life, though. But you were never aware of the process.”

“As absurd as that sounds, how could I have made you?”

“That’s what you’re here to find out,” she said, taking his free hand.

“Something tells me you already know. Why can’t you tell me?”

“It’s for you to figure out.”

They reached the middle of the ground, students skipping past them, some grinning, some laughing. It took the old man another five minutes before he set eyes on his younger self. The bespectacled boy was alone. “That’s me,” said the old man, pointing.

Instead of nodding or saying anything, the woman snapped her fingers, taking them into a room. It was a dim and grim place with only light filtering through cracks in the window and the bottom of the door. The same boy, in the same clothes he had worn at school, sat at the foot of his bed, reading a comic book by a flashlight. Many pictures filled the wall: our solar system with all the planets, Albert Einstein, superheroes, the Milky Way, and more. A yellow sticky note on the side of his computer screen read:

***You're never really alone if the night sky can listen to you.* ~ (An old man once told me this—I guess he's dead now).**

"What did you desire most at the time?" the woman asked.

"Isn't it obvious? Friends."

Shaking her head, the woman snapped her fingers.

They were back at the school grounds on another day. The bespectacled boy had made some friends, but he didn't seem to be fitting in. Maybe he was made the butt of a joke as he trailed behind the boys, lowering his head.

"You do have friends," the woman observed, looking bemused.

"Belonging, I suppose," the old man said.

The woman clicked her tongue. "Many kids struggle to find their place among their peers and society. They're all the same. It doesn't make you special." She snapped her fingers.

"You're overgeneralizing the issues children go through at that age," he complained when they landed on a lakeside where schoolkids were camping. "Show me my older selves, and then we can see how problems break free from generic childhood struggles."

“Mind you, the main purpose of our tour isn’t to revisit your childhood and adulthood problems.”

“But don’t you see?” the old man said. “It’s during our lowest points that our unfulfilled desires rise to the surface.”

“If that’s the path you’d prefer to travel, then who am I to object? I would gladly fulfill that request. However, our time is running out. Your residual neural activity would allow us a few minutes at most. We could stretch that, of course, but there’s always a breaking point. So, bear that in mind.”

The old man nodded, though he couldn’t see his younger self carving a message—while his friends played volleyball—into the trunk of a tree with a hunting knife:

Look, look—I took a chunk out of the stardust.

Snap!

It was the first day of college. Among a sea of students and parents, there was a lonely young man, carrying a suitcase, weaving through the crowd, trying not to look at anyone. He had a backpack slung over his shoulder. By now, the old man’s memory had been jogged to the point that he didn’t need a second look to recognize his younger selves, so he approached the lonely young man with all the love and empathy he could muster.

“Your desire for parents, clearly?” the woman said, coming up next to him.

“My mother died when I was a little boy; my father, weeks before I started college.”

“It must have been a horrible phase for you,” she said. “The lowest point, huh?”

“Not even close,” he said, a grandfatherly look in his eyes as he saw his younger self pass him by.

“Despite the fact that your girlfriend also died a year prior to that? Didn’t you love her?”

“You mean, ‘Didn’t you love *me*?’” the old man said teasingly.

The woman rolled her eyes, grinning.

Snap!

A high school boy and a girl sat side by side on a sand dune. Except for their Jeep, there was nothing for miles and miles in every direction but starlit sand with wrinkles and bulges. The Milky Way blazed in its full glory, a luminescent arc, though its center was blotted by gas and dust. The boy pointed at a meteor lancing across the sky, said something, and the girl giggled, leaning into his shoulder.

“See how happy you two were?” the woman said.

“One of the most memorable nights of my life, for sure. We had our first kiss.”

While the girl clicked pictures of the sky, the boy drew in the sand with a jagged rock:

The writing shall fade, yet the intention behind it is eternal.

Snap!

The boy and the girl were celebrating her birthday.

Snap!

The boy and the girl were riding bicycles in the rain, laughing like two idiots, as if they hadn’t a care in the world.

Snap!

The boy and the girl munched on potato chips while playing a video game.

Snap!

They arrived at a concert.

“Stop,” the old man said. “I get it now.”

“Too painful to watch?” She snapped her fingers, and they arrived on a cliff. Before them, three waterfalls splashed down into an emerald-green lake.

“No—you’re trying to waste our limited time.”

“How can you say that?” The woman sounded a bit testy.

“Revisiting these memories isn’t helpful, as I suspect you already embody the endpoint of the underlying longing in each of these snippets. I might go so far as to say you’re doing it on purpose. For what it’s worth, I remember imagining various versions of how our lives could’ve turned out had my girlfriend not met with that accident.”

“Yet you didn’t try to find another partner? Neither in college nor afterward.”

“Like I just said,” he replied, “my imagination kept getting in the way of meaningful relationships. Perhaps that’s one of the reasons why I couldn’t discover anything noteworthy as an astrophysicist.”

“Could’ve tried to be a writer.”

The old man looked across the lake thoughtfully. “I tried a few times, but putting an intangible idea into words felt like caging a free-spirited bird. It felt like an insult to the idea.”

“Where to now?” she asked.

“Somewhere I’m much older than a naïve teenager,” he said.

Snap!

They were inside a lecture hall. The old man looked at his middle-aged self, who shared more physical similarities than any other version. He had chalked on the blackboard:

In pursuit of the unknown, we’re doomed to stay one step behind.

It was a class on cosmic inflation. The professor was writing a string of complex mathematical equations.

“Wait,” the old man said, holding up his hand, as the woman was about to snap her fingers. “Wait a minute.” He walked down the aisle toward the blackboard and read his own quote. “I’m starting to get it,” he added. “I *did* create you, so I can do this too.”

And he snapped his fingers.

The woman smiled as they found themselves in an auditorium. A middle-aged professor stood behind a podium, gripping the mic, oblivious to his older self watching him from the audience, beyond the veil of death. People of all ages occupied the seats, but high school and college students were in the majority. The professor explained his recent theory about how it was possible to gauge the conditions of an exoplanet—even planets in other galaxies—with almost 99.999999% accuracy. “Here’s the best part!” the professor added enthusiastically. “We’ll be able to “simulate” the exact conditions on Venus. Before you ask why Venus, let me first explain that it’ll somewhat be like terraforming a planet, mimicking the conditions—at least the

topography—of the exoplanet. Now you must know why I've chosen Venus as a practice ground."

A dozen self-important scientists seated in the back smirked, some shaking their heads.

"Blending quantum entanglement and closed timelike curves together would allow us to make it into a reality," the professor went on. Some of the smirks were wiped clean off the faces. "Imagine how profound it will be to finally be able to see alien mountains, rivers, valleys, canyons, forests, you name it. The Venusian surface and atmosphere would act as our simulation ground, letting us project the topography of exoplanets into it."

Since he knew there were younger students watching him, he simplified his theory by saying that quantum entanglement involved pairing (or "entangling") two atomic or subatomic particles, where a change to one automatically brought about the same change in the other almost instantly, no matter how far apart they were. And as for closed timelike curves, it was all about interacting with one's past self—but it could also apply to two entangled particles.

"We could potentially recreate the conditions of an exoplanet on Venus," the professor said, about to wrap up his presentation. "And not just the way it was, but also the way it is now. Conventional means—such as the findings of space telescopes—have already made it possible to measure the spectrum of an exoplanet, which reveals the exact chemical composition of its atmosphere. It's time we used that for something grander. Any questions?"

Practically every hand in the room went up.

Outside the auditorium, an elderly researcher approached him and said, "You should consider a career as a science fiction author."

Laughing, the middle-aged professor replied, “What a way to compliment and insult an astrophysicist at the same time.”

His older self, standing a ways off with the woman he had supposedly “created,” chuckled at his younger self. Even she couldn’t help but smile. “I think I’m very close to finding my lifelong desire,” he told the woman and snapped his fingers.

They arrived in a dimly lit dorm room. The boy sat at his table, writing something in his diary under the light of the table lamp. The old man walked up to him and leaned over his shoulder to read:

Once you told me a bedtime story, Dad,

when I was a boy,

when you and I grieved for the same person:

Your wife,

my mom.

I imagined the story’s world was as real as our own.

But then, you told me it was just a story.

That none of it was real.

You tucked me into bed.

You said good night.

I fell asleep.

I dreamt of some aspects of the story world that night.

The aspects that you didn't include in the story.

(How bizarre!)

I woke up the next morning,

and wondered:

"Where do dreams come from?"

Clasping her hands behind her back, the woman leaned over the boy's other shoulder and exchanged a glance with the old man. "So you were a poet too," she said.

"I don't know why, but I was feeling particularly nostalgic that night. This poem sowed the seeds of a hunger to know the unknown, as if I were actually there. But it came at a cost that might sound silly: a fear of missing out."

"You don't say!" The woman snorted. "And it is a silly fear. Extremely silly."

"For all my life, I was overcome with this crippling feeling of trying to know what was happening on the other side of the globe, say, in a small town in Peru that I hadn't even heard of, wondering how people—the people I'd never ever get to meet—were going about their lives at any given moment: what they were talking about, what they were reading, what they were buying, and more. Whenever I engaged in an activity or hung out with someone in college, I always feared what else I could be doing or who else I could be with. I know that sounds preposterous, but that is exactly why I isolated myself in my later years, after retirement."

"To think?" she asked somberly.

“To think truthfully.”

“What’s that?”

“Believing in my thoughts,” he said. “Really, really believing in ‘em.”

“You mean daydreaming?”

“In a sense, yes.” He snapped his fingers.

They arrived in the middle of a busy street. It was a small town in Peru.

“But the question is,” the woman said, gesturing around, “is it real? Is any of this real?” There was a challenge in her tone, a kind of challenge the old man was fond of undertaking.

Snap!

They arrived at a riverside, except it didn’t look like a regular river. Round creatures bobbed up and down in red waters, except it wasn’t water but a different liquid that shot up into the air in angry spurts, which were gobbled up by countless low-flying birds, except they weren’t like regular birds. They had four wings—two in the front and two in the back. Next, the old man noticed a gleaming white arc in the sky—a ring—an orange sun, and two moons: one purple, a half-moon, and the other rusty-brown, a full moon.

“Is this real?” the woman asked again, and the old man didn’t answer yet. “Is this a real planet or all in your head?”

Behind the old man and the woman was a line of strange trees. Their yellow trunks were evenly spaced, but their branches and pink leaves writhed together like boys tangled in a fistfight.

“What I’m seeing right now is as real as you,” the old man said at last. “One day, humanity will land on this planet. I don’t know what kind of technology they’ll use, but I do know one thing for certain: their desire to explore, the root of their mission. What I’m doing right now is breaking causality, something my theory required in real life. But it doesn’t matter, since I won’t be there to tell anyone. Because the last of my neural activity is firing up wildly, I have moved forward in time, reshaping the pathways to mirror those of an explorer setting foot on this planet for the very first time.”

“And you based that on humanity’s innate desire to explore the unknown,” she said. “Well done.”

“Let’s sit down for a while,” he said softly. “I’m tired.”

“Where?”

“Where it all began,” he said, snapping his fingers.

They returned to the starlit desert. The boy and the girl still sat side by side on the sand dune, the boy still pointing at the Milky Way, and their Jeep still parked in the distance. The old man lowered himself beside his teenage self, while the woman sat next to the girl.

It was a few minutes before the two of them began to fade—but not before witnessing the boy and the girl share a kiss. “Thank you,” the old man said to the woman. And those were his final words on his journey to fulfill his lifelong desire.